



CHINA'S HARDLINE STRATEGY IS AIMED AT EXPANDING ITS TERRITORIAL CLAIMS DURING THE BORDER TALKS WITH INDIA.

While government sources did not want to officially comment on the incident, External Affairs Minister Pranab Mukherjee raised the issue, also citing the intrusions in Sikkim, at the official meeting in Beijing. The Chinese leadership, however, responded with the lame excuse that both countries held differing perceptions on the boundaries. Still, the question is: why did Mukherjee, who had met his Chinese counterpart Yang Jiechi only a month ago at a trilateral meeting, go to Beijing without a substantive agenda?

The Chinese, who are known as protocol perfectionists, gave a cold welcome to Mukherjee. The Indian minister was not given an audience with President Hu Jintao. Premier Wen Jiabao cancelled his talks with Mukherjee, saying he had to make an urgent visit to earthquake-affected areas, even though the meeting was fixed much in advance. Mukherjee's meeting with Vice-President Xi Jinping, who, it is believed, is being groomed to take over from Hu in 2012, was the only saving grace.

The Indian minister was not just snubbed. He was denied an opportunity to raise the intrusion issue with the highest levels of Chinese leadership, given the fact that he had already discussed it with his Chinese counterpart Jiechi when they had met on the sidelines of the trilateral meeting.

have seen the Chinese in a belligerent position. "Going by the series of high level visits by Indian leaders, we seem overzealous to please the Chinese," Chellaney adds.

The dispute between the two countries involves the longest contested boundary in the world. China claims 92,000 sq km of Indian territory. On the other hand, the Indian contention is that China is in possession of approximately 38,000 sq km of Indian territory in Jammu & Kashmir under the so-called China-Pakistan Boundary Agreement of 1963. Pakistan also illegally ceded 5,180 sq km of Indian territory in Pakistan-oc-

there is a weak leadership in India, incapable of taking important diplomatic decisions. Beijing wants the border dispute to linger on and is bullying India. It also thinks that Delhi is busy cosying up to Washington.

With Delhi going on a backfoot on various issues such as Tibet, and not being able to leverage its relationship with Taiwan, China now believes that it has got what it wanted from India. So there is little left for India to bargain with China.

Such brinkmanships help China militarily. With no demarcation of the **COLD VIBES: Mukherjee (centre) with Yang (right) in Beijing**



FOREIGN MINISTER PRANAB MUKHERJEE'S ATTEMPTS TO RAISE THE ISSUE OF INTRUSIONS WERE STONEWALLED BY THE CHINESE.



Even before Mukherjee had left Delhi, the governor of the quake-hit Sichuan province backed out after agreeing to be in the capital with the Indian external affairs minister to receive relief materials. Instead, the vice-governor, who is much junior according to protocol, was deputed by the Chinese Government to accept relief materials from Mukherjee.

"All these incidents are a part of growing muscle-flexing by the Chinese against India," says strategic analyst Brahma Chellaney. The last two years

cupied Kashmir to China. The two sides held about a dozen rounds of boundary negotiations but the talks made little progress. The big question is: why would China want to resort to such offensive tactics at a time when the country needs India's support most? The Beijing Olympics, scheduled to be held next month, are already mired in a controversy as the host country faces flak for its oppressive activities in Tibet.

According to analysts, the first reason is the Chinese assessment that

border, over three lakh Indian soldiers remain tied down to the India-China border, which is also a drain on India's economic capabilities. It affects India's efforts to project itself as a military power in the region.

To keep the friendship intact, China should respect India's territorial integrity and India, on its part, needs to raise the issue at the highest levels of Chinese leadership. Small sparks on the border can lead to a big fire that the two neighbours may find very difficult to contain.